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N

nation

A **nation** is a group of people who belong together. These people usually live in the same country and have the same ruler.

Sometimes people use the word nation to refer to a people group who have something in common, even if those people do not have a king or a country. A people group may be descendants from the same person or share a similar purpose. For example, the nation of Israel was a people group before they had their own land or king because the Israelites were all descendants of the same man. The nation of Israel was also a nation because God chose the Israelites to be God's special people. Sometimes translations simply call these kinds of groups "people." The Israelites especially liked to call themselves the "people of Yahweh," or the "people of Israel," rather than a nation. The Israelites often called non-Israelite groups of people who belonged together "nations." Yahweh promised Abraham that Yahweh would bless all the nations of the earth through Abraham's descendants. We see that Yahweh kept his promise when Jesus' disciples shared the good news about Jesus not just to the Israelite nation but to all people groups.

Whenever the Bible talks about "all the nations of the earth," this is another way to say "all the people who live on earth."

nation

Audio Content
mp3 file (806 KB)

Nazareth

Nazareth is a small town in the region of Galilee, in the north of Israel. Nazareth does not appear in the Old Testament, and the first time we hear about this town is when we hear that Mary and Joseph, Jesus's parents, came from Nazareth. Jesus was born in a village called Bethlehem, in Judea, but when he was still small Mary and Joseph went to live in Nazareth. Therefore Jesus was later called a Nazarene, which means someone from Nazareth. That was not a compliment. The Jews from Judea looked down on the people in Galilee, and even the people within Galilee looked down on people from Nazareth, because it was a small and unimportant town.

Nazareth

Audio Content
mp3 file (534 KB)

neighbor

In the Bible, the word "neighbor" often means the people in your community. People also used the word "neighbors" to refer to people groups who lived in the same land area or region. In God's law, God gave a lot of instructions about how to love your neighbor as you love yourself. Sometimes people thought that this meant that you only had to love people in your community who were from the same people group as you. In the New Testament, Jesus explained that a neighbor can mean anyone with whom you come into contact, no matter who the other person is! In some cases in the New Testament, authors used the word "neighbor" to refer to fellow believers.

neighbor

Audio Content
mp3 file (425 KB)